

Switzer Fellowship: Trauma-Informed Approaches in Centers for Independent Living (2020)

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Switzer Project: Trauma-Informed Approaches in Centers for Independent Living

Background:

People with disabilities are disproportionately impacted by trauma, yet trauma-informed care (TIC) models are not widely implemented in disability service agencies.

Goal:

Understand how TIC models and practices are or can be implemented within Centers for Independent Living (CILs)

Defining the Problem

Trauma-Informed Care

Lack of safety

Traumatic
experiences

**Disempowering
Systems**

Independent Living

Lack of accessibility

Ableism

**Disempowering
Systems**

Identifying Solutions

Trauma-Informed Care

Peer Support

Safety

Collaboration & Mutuality

Empowerment Voice & Choice

Trustworthiness & Transparency

Intersectionality

Independent Living

Peer Support

Removal of Barriers

Self-Help

Consumer Control

Civil Rights & Advocacy

Cross-Disability

Methods

CIL Staff Interviews (7)

CIL Consumer Interviews (7)

Document review

Observation

2020: Need to Pivot

Challenges/circumstances

- COVID-19 pandemic and racial reckoning
- Ongoing trauma, including racial trauma
- CIL offices shut down
- New/temporary policies and practices
- Low response – slow recruitment
- Fraudulent responses to screening survey

Responses

- All activities online/remote
- Used trauma-informed principles in research
- No in-person participant observation
 - Attended public online events and one staff meeting
 - Online “tour” by CIL staff
- Expanded outreach beyond MA
- Survey security measures, changed outreach

Findings

CIL practices are largely consistent with TIC principles.

Consumers felt empowered and supported in making choices that were right for them.

Staff and consumers generally felt safe and supported; staff wanted more training on crisis intervention.

As disability-led organizations, CILs foster TIC principles of empowerment, voice, and choice among both staff and consumers.

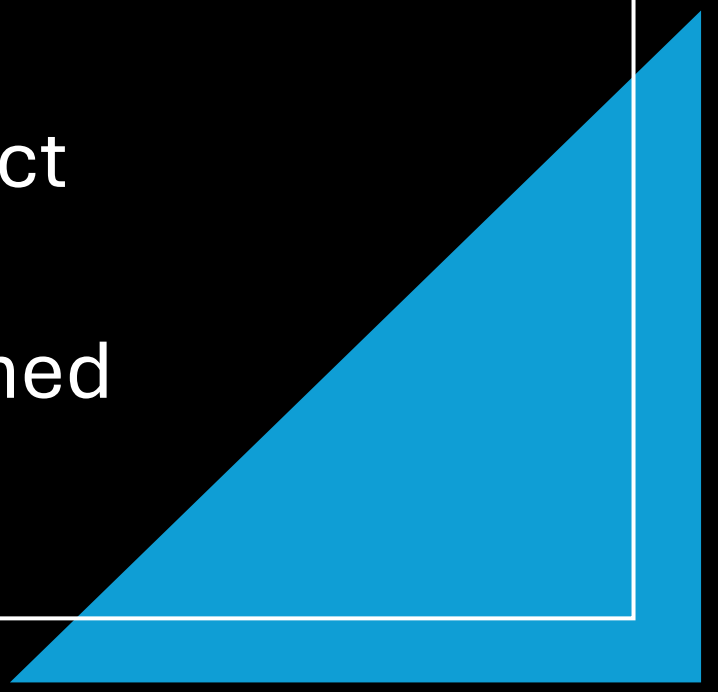
Organizations implementing trauma-informed practices might look to the independent living movement and CILs as models.

Since the Switzer: Qualitative research/evaluation and community-based projects

- PI on an ACL-funded National Centers of Excellence in Community Collaborations for Employment grant
- NIDILRR-funded projects:
 - RRTC on Equity in Employment for Multiply Marginalized People with Disabilities (Langston University)
 - Mentor researchers at MSIs (Langston U RRTC)
 - KT DRRP – Rural Youth Apprenticeship Development
 - DRRP on Scaling Up Progressive Employment
- Evaluations of RSA-funded VR Model Demonstrations



Tips

- Use your work plan
 - Be flexible
 - Reach out to colleagues/mentors, project officer
 - Document challenges and lessons learned
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Contact

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